

CS 112

Introduction to Data Structures

WEEK 08

Algorithm Analysis and Big-Oh

Eric Araújo

Calvin University · Fall 2026

This Week

- 1 Counting operations
- 2 From counts to classes
- 3 Big-Oh notation
- 4 Why constants drop out
- 5 The curves that matter **KEY**
- 6 Reading complexity off code
- 7 Why it matters at scale

How Long Does This Take?

```
v[i]                // 3 operations, always  
  
v.push_back(it)     // 5 operations if there's room  
                   // ~3n + 5 if it must grow  
  
list.push_front(it) // 4 operations, always
```

Counting exact operations is honest but useless for comparing algorithms — the number depends on the compiler, the machine, the mood of the cache. What we actually care about is **how the cost changes as n grows**.

Two Things We Don't Care About

Constant factors

$$3n + 5$$
$$100n + 2000$$

Both grow *proportionally to n*. Double n, double the work.

Lower-order terms

$$n^2 + 50n + 700$$

At $n = 1000$, the n^2 term is 20× everything else combined.

So we throw both away and keep only the term that dominates. What's left is the **order of growth**.

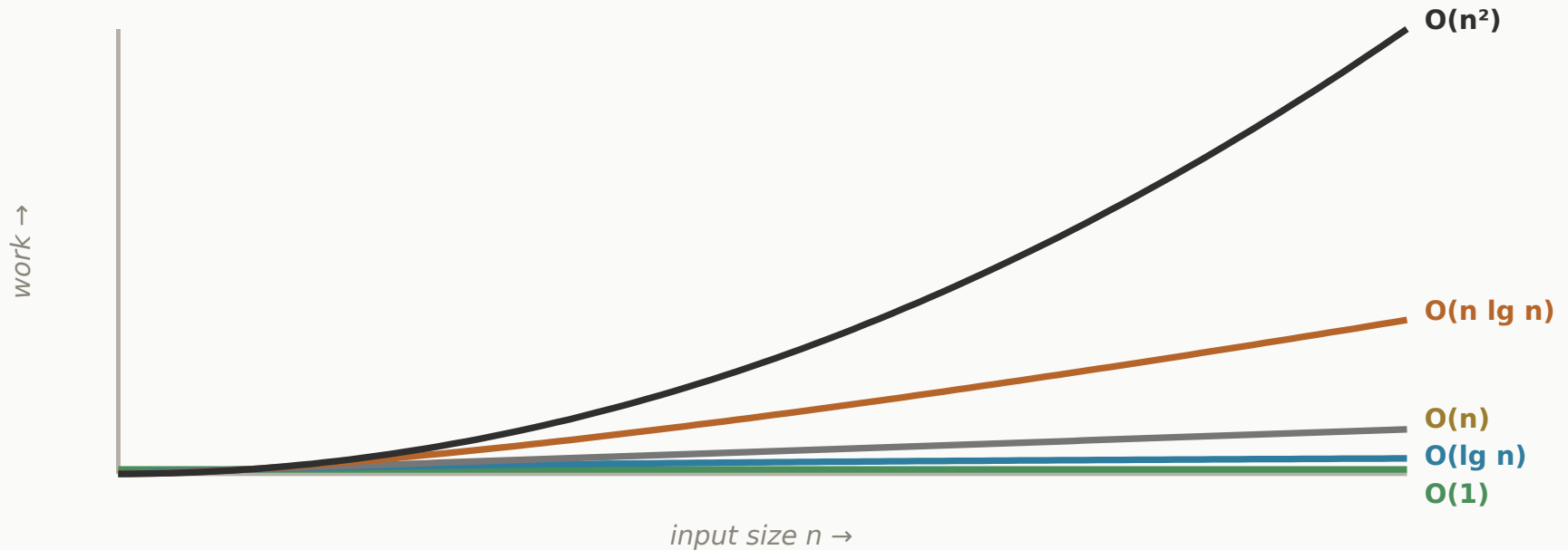
Big-Oh Notation

We write **$O(f(n))$** — "on the order of f of n ".

Exact count	Big-Oh	Name
3	$O(1)$	constant
$\log_2 n + 4$	$O(\lg n)$	logarithmic
$3n + 5$	$O(n)$	linear
$2n \lg n + n$	$O(n \lg n)$	linearithmic
$n^2 + 50n + 700$	$O(n^2)$	quadratic
2^n	$O(2^n)$	exponential

Big-Oh is an *upper bound on the shape of the growth*, not a promise about seconds.

The Curves That Matter



Near the origin the differences look academic. That is exactly why they surprise people in production — the gap only opens up once the data gets big.

TALK TO YOUR NEIGHBOR · TTYN

An algorithm takes $4n + 200$ steps. Its complexity is...

A. $O(4n)$

B. $O(n)$

C. $O(n + 200)$

D. $O(200)$

Reading It Off the Code

```
for (int i = 0; i < n; ++i) {  
    total += a[i];  
}
```

One loop over $n \rightarrow \mathbf{O(n)}$

```
for (int i = 0; i < n; ++i) {  
    for (int j = 0; j < n; ++j) {  
        if (a[i] == a[j]) ...  
    }  
}
```

Loop inside a loop $\rightarrow \mathbf{O(n^2)}$

Rule of thumb: loops *in sequence* add (keep the biggest), loops *nested* multiply. Halving the problem each pass gives you a $\lg n$.

What is the complexity of this loop?

```
for (int i = 1; i < n; i = i * 2) {  
    cout << i << endl;  
}
```

- A. $O(n)$
- B. $O(n^2)$
- C. $O(\lg n)$
- D. $O(n \lg n)$

What We've Built So Far

Operation	Dynamic array	Linked list
index <code>v[i]</code>	$O(1)$	$O(n)$
append	$O(1)$ amortized	$O(1)$
prepend	$O(n)$	$O(1)$
insert / remove at position	$O(n)$	$O(n)$
search (unsorted)	$O(n)$	$O(n)$
traverse everything	$O(n)$	$O(n)$

The same table you filled in by counting, now in the language everyone uses.

Why This Matters: Searching

One million items, and you need to find one.

Approach	Complexity	Comparisons
Linear search	$O(n)$	up to 1,000,000
Binary search (sorted)	$O(\lg n)$	about 20

Fifty thousand times less work — from the same data, just organised differently. That is the entire argument for this course.

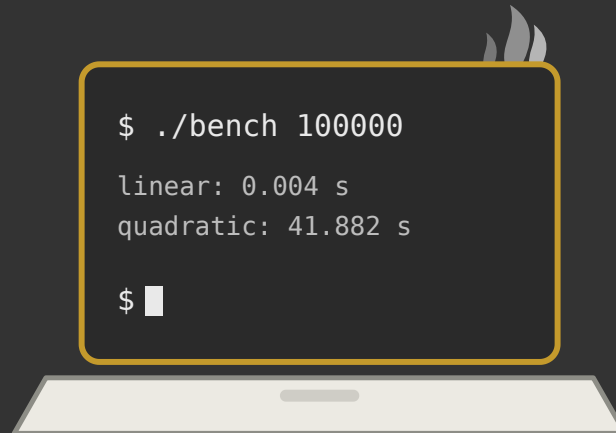
Why This Matters: Sorting

Sorting those same million items:

Algorithm	Complexity	Rough operations
Bubble sort	$O(n^2)$	10^{12} — hours
Merge / quick sort	$O(n \lg n)$	2×10^7 — under a second

Same computer, same data, same answer. The only difference is the shape of the growth curve — and it's the difference between a coffee break and a lunch break you never come back from.

Demo



Timing $O(n)$ against $O(n^2)$ on real data.

(the graph explains itself around $n = 10,000$)

TALK TO YOUR NEIGHBOR · TTYN

Algorithm A is $O(n^2)$, algorithm B is $O(n \lg n)$. Which should you use?

- A.** Always B — it has the better complexity
- B.** Always A — simpler code runs faster
- C.** B for large n ; for small n , A may well be faster
- D.** Whichever is easier to write

Overloading << for Your Container

```
// in List.h
ostream& operator<<(ostream &out, const List &list);

// in List.cpp
ostream& operator<<(ostream &out, const List &list) {
    list.writeTo(out);
    return out;
}
```

Week 3's rule again: a free function, taking the stream on the left, returning the stream so it chains. Traversing the whole list to print it is $O(n)$ — as you'd expect.

Week 08 Recap

- Big-Oh describes **how work grows with n** , not seconds on a clock
- Drop constant factors and lower-order terms — keep the dominant one
- Nested loops multiply; halving the problem gives $\lg n$
- $O(1) < O(\lg n) < O(n) < O(n \lg n) < O(n^2) < O(2^n)$
- At a million items the difference is a second versus an afternoon

Next: a08 →

This deck stands on earlier CS112 materials by
Joel Adams and **Victor Norman** · adapted and extended by **Eric Araújo**

